



N.E.S.T

NURTURING EDUCATION WITH SCHOOL & THERAPY

Signs to Look For Before Age 3

A Parent's Early Development Checklist

A free guide from N.E.S.T Special Education & Therapy Center
DHA Phase 2, Sector G, Islamabad

12 MO

18 MO

2 YRS

2.5-3 YRS

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Before You Begin

Every child grows at their own pace, and a little variation from one milestone chart to the next is completely normal. But research is clear on one thing: the earlier a developmental difference is noticed, the more options parents have, and the better children tend to respond to support.

This checklist isn't a diagnostic tool and it isn't meant to worry you. It's meant to help you notice patterns, trust your instincts, and know when a professional opinion is worth getting. If you're raising a child in Islamabad or DHA and something on this list feels familiar, you're not alone, and help is closer than you think.

4

Age Bands
Covered

3

Development
Areas

2-20

Ages N.E.S.T
Supports

A quick note before we start

This guide touches on signs linked to speech and language delay, autism spectrum differences, ADHD, and general developmental delay. One or two items alone rarely mean much. A pattern across several areas, or a skill that's clearly regressing, is what's worth paying attention to.

1

By 12 Months

- Doesn't respond to their name being called
- No babbling (like "ba-ba" or "da-da") by 9-12 months
- Doesn't point, wave bye-bye, or reach to be picked up
- Little to no eye contact during feeding or play
- Doesn't react to loud sounds or seem to notice familiar voices

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

Most babies babble playfully, respond to their name most of the time, and enjoy back-and-forth games like peekaboo by this age.

- Says fewer than 6-10 words
- Doesn't point to show you something interesting ("look at that!")
- Doesn't imitate sounds, gestures, or simple actions (clapping, blowing a kiss)
- Seems unaware of other children or uninterested in shared play
- Unusually intense reactions to routine changes, textures, sounds, or lights

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

Toddlers at this age usually have a growing word bank, point to share interest, and copy simple actions they see adults do.

- No two-word phrases ("more juice," "mama up")
- Vocabulary isn't growing — stuck at the same handful of words for months
- Doesn't follow simple one-step instructions ("bring me the ball")
- Limited pretend play (not feeding a doll, not "talking" on a toy phone)
- Extreme difficulty with transitions, or very limited range of interests/play

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

Most 2-year-olds combine words, follow simple instructions, and enjoy early pretend play, even if speech is still developing.

4

By 2.5–3 Years

- Speech is hard for even family members to understand
- Doesn't combine words into short sentences
- Doesn't ask simple questions or engage in back-and-forth conversation
- Very high activity level, impulsivity, or inability to sit for even short routines
- Loses words or skills they previously had (this one especially deserves a conversation with your pediatrician, regardless of age)

TYPICAL AT THIS AGE

Children this age typically speak in short sentences understood by familiar adults, and can sit through a short story or meal.

What to Do If You Notice These Signs

Take a breath first. Noticing early is a good thing, not a crisis.

- **Start with your pediatrician.** Mention specifically what you've observed — they can rule out hearing issues or refer you onward.
- **Ask for a developmental or speech-language screening.** These are low-risk, non-invasive, and often take less than an hour.
- **Don't wait for “maybe it'll resolve itself.”** Early intervention has the strongest evidence behind it of anything we do in this field — the earlier, the more effective.
- **Trust yourself.** You spend more time with your child than any clinician ever will. If something feels off, it's worth a conversation, even if everyone around you says to wait.

How N.E.S.T Can Help

We work with children ages 2 to 20 across autism, ADHD, Down syndrome, speech and language delays, and other developmental needs, right here in DHA Phase 2, Islamabad. Our assessment process is warm and unhurried — we spend real time observing your child, talking with you about what you've noticed at home, and building a picture together before anyone uses a label.

BOOK AN ASSESSMENT